

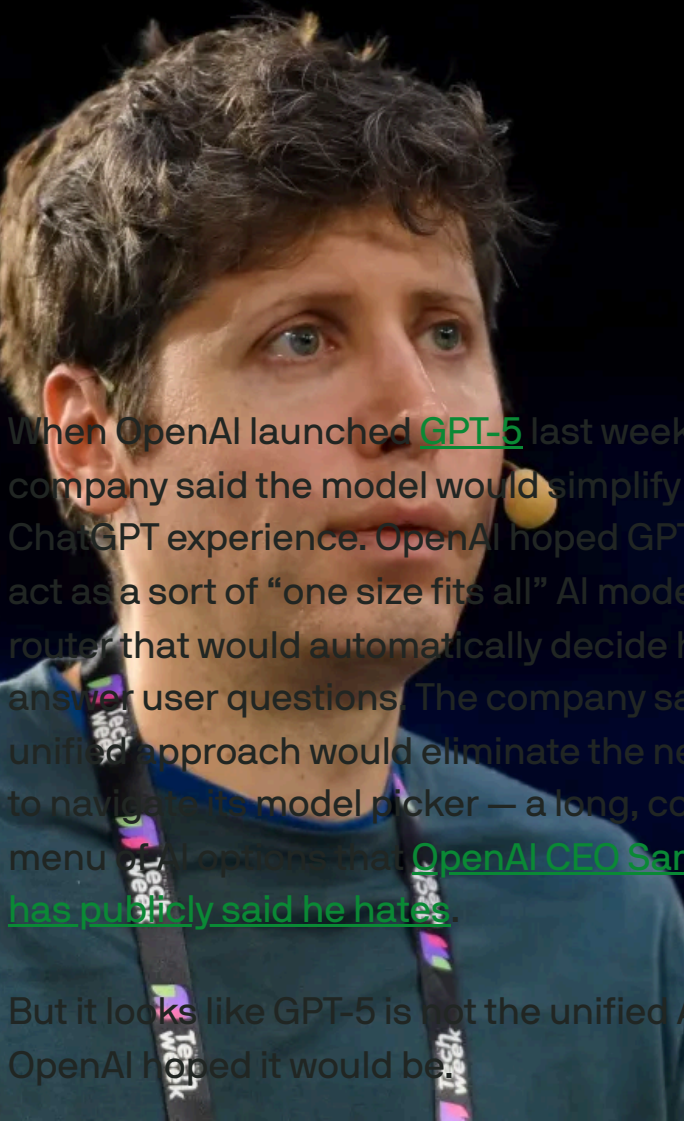
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AI



ChatGPT's model picker  
is back, and it's  
complicated



When OpenAI launched [GPT-5](#) last week, the company said the model would simplify the ChatGPT experience. OpenAI hoped GPT-5 would act as a sort of “one size fits all” AI model with a router that would automatically decide how to best answer user questions. The company said this unified approach would eliminate the need for users to navigate its model picker — a long, complicated menu of AI options that [OpenAI CEO Sam Altman has publicly said he hates](#).

But it looks like GPT-5 is not the unified AI model OpenAI hoped it would be.

IMAGE CREDITS:

STEFANO GUIDI / GETTY IMAGES

Altman said in a [post on X](#) Tuesday that the company introduced new “Auto,” “Fast,” and “Thinking” settings for GPT-5 that all ChatGPT users can select from the model picker. The Auto setting seems to work like GPT-5’s model router that OpenAI initially announced; however, the company is also giving users options to circumnavigate it, allowing them to access fast and slow responding AI models directly.

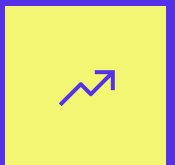
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## Updates to ChatGPT:

You can now choose between “Auto”, “Fast”, and “Thinking” for GPT-5. Most users will want Auto, but the additional control will be useful for some people.

Rate limits are now 3,000 messages/week with GPT-5 Thinking, and then extra capacity on GPT-5 Thinking [Show more](#)

6:19 AM · Aug 13, 2025



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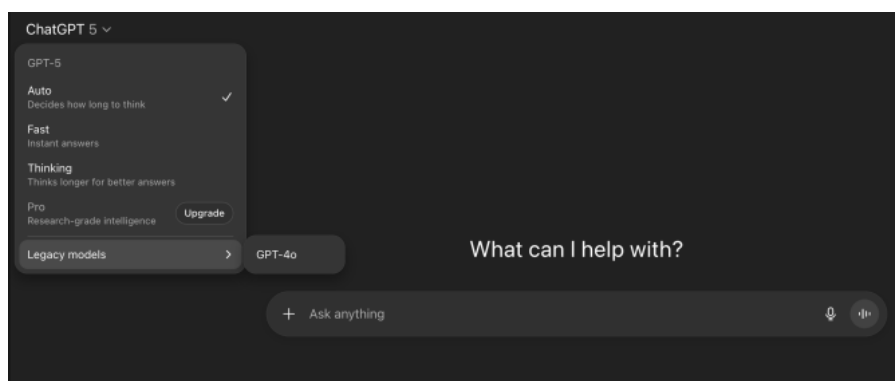


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Alongside GPT-5’s new modes, Altman said that paid users can once again access several legacy AI models — including GPT-4o, GPT-4.1, and o3 — which were deprecated just last week. GPT-4o is now in the model picker by default, while other AI models can be added from ChatGPT’s settings.

“We are working on an update to GPT-5’s personality which should feel warmer than the current personality but not as annoying (to most users) as GPT-4o,” Altman wrote in the post on X. “However, one learning for us from the past few days is we really just need to get to a world with more per-user customization of model personality.”



CHATGPT’S MODEL PICKER NOW FEATURES SEVERAL OPTIONS.

IMAGE CREDITS:OPENAI/MAXWELL ZEFF

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ChatGPT's model picker now seems to be as complicated as ever, suggesting that GPT-5's model router has not universally satisfied users as the company hoped. The expectations for GPT-5 were sky high, with many hoping that OpenAI would push the limits of AI models like it had with the launch of GPT-4. However, GPT-5's rollout has been rougher than expected.

The deprecation of GPT-4o and other AI models in ChatGPT sparked a [backlash among users](#) who had grown attached to the AI models' responses and personalities in ways that OpenAI had not anticipated. In the future, Altman says the company will give users plenty of advance notice if it ever deprecates GPT-4o.



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GPT-5's model router also appeared to be largely broken on launch day. That caused some users to feel the AI model wasn't as performant as previous OpenAI models, and forced Altman to address the problem in an [AMA session on Reddit](#). However, it

seems that GPT-5's router may still not be satisfying for all users.

“We’re not always going to get everything on try #1 but I am very proud of how quickly the team can iterate,” wrote OpenAI’s VP of ChatGPT, Nick Turley, in a [post on X](#) Tuesday.

Routing prompts to the right AI model is a difficult task that requires aligning an AI model to a user’s preferences, as well as the specific question they’re asking. The router then has to make a decision on which AI model to send the prompt to in just a split second — that way, if a prompt goes to a fast-responding AI model, the response can still be fast.

More broadly, some people exhibit preferences for AI models that go beyond fast or slow responses. Some users may like the verbosity of one AI model, while others might appreciate the contrarian answers of another.

Human attachment to certain AI models is a relatively new concept that isn’t well understood. For example, hundreds of people in San Francisco recently [held a funeral](#) for Anthropic’s AI model, Claude 3 Sonnet, when it was taken offline. In other cases, AI chatbots seem to be contributing to people struggling with mental health issues going down [unhealthy rabbit holes](#).

It seems OpenAI has more work to do around aligning its AI models to individual user preferences.

Topics: [AI](#) [ChatGPT](#) [OpenAI](#) [sam altman](#)





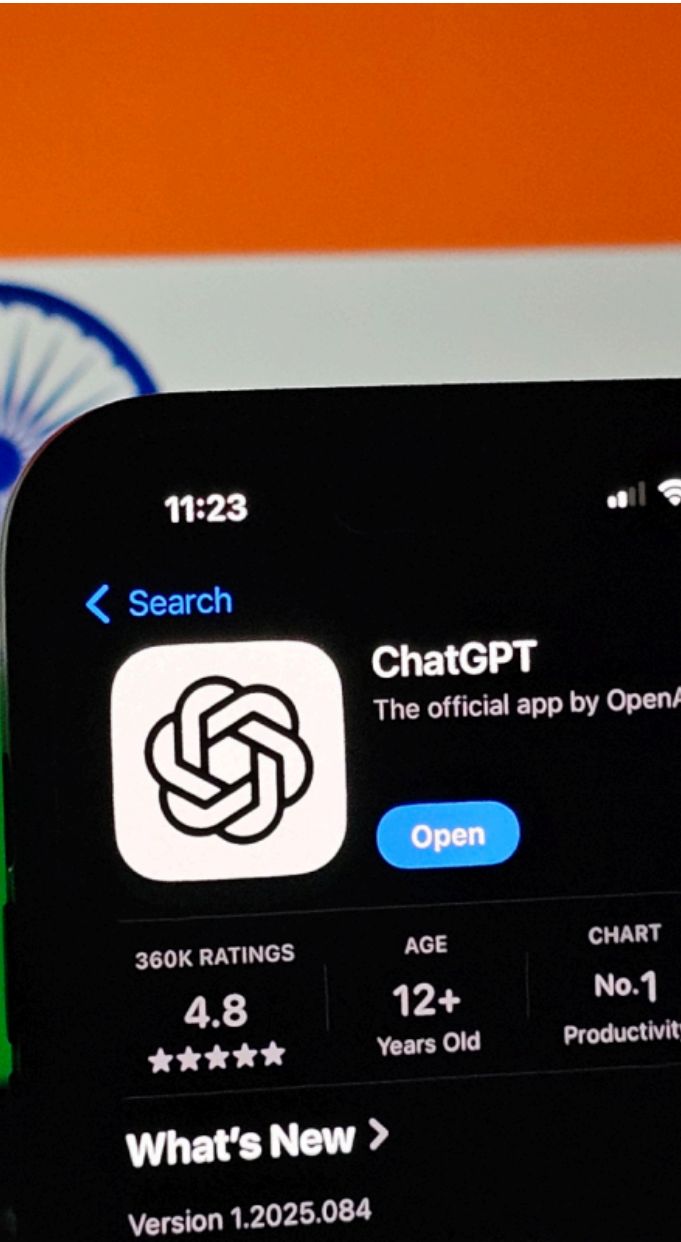
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Maxwell Zeff is a senior reporter at TechCrunch specializing in AI. Previously with Gizmodo, Bloomberg, and MSNBC,...

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APPS



## OpenAI launches a sub-\$5 ChatGPT plan in India

Ivan Mehta — 8:57 PM PDT · August 18, 2025

IMAGE CREDITS: JAGMEET SINGH / TECHCRUNCH

OpenAI today launched a new, cheaper ChatGPT paid subscription plan in India called ChatGPT GO, priced at ₹399 per month (\$4.60), which is more affordable than the ₹1,999 (about \$23) per month Plus Plan.



The company had turned on local currency pricing for all its plans a few days ago, and with this launch, it will also allow users to pay through UPI (Unified Payment Interface), India’s payment framework.

Nick Turley, VP at OpenAI and head of ChatGPT, said that this plan will increase the message, image generation, and file uploads by 10 times over the free tier. The ChatGPT Go plan will also enable better memory retention for more personalized responses, Turely said.

We just launched ChatGPT Go in India, a new subscription tier that gives users in India more access to our most popular features: 10x higher message limits, 10x more image generations, 10x more file uploads, and 2x longer memory compared with our free tier. All for Rs. 399. 🇮🇳

— Nick Turley (@nickaturley) [August 19, 2025](#)

“Making ChatGPT more affordable has been a key ask from users! We’re rolling out Go in India first and will learn from feedback before expanding to other countries,” Turley said.

From a currency conversion standpoint, the Plus plan was higher than \$20 for Indian users when offered in local currency. The new Go plan offers a more affordable alternative to people who are looking to use ChatGPT primarily for chat, image generation, and file processing.

Tibor Blaho, a software engineer with a reputation for accurately leaking upcoming AI products, had [previously teased](#) this plan and its details.

While the company is geo-restricting this plan to India, the company said on its [support page](#) that it is working to expand this plan to more regions.

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Last month, Turley noted that ChatGPT now has more than [700 million weekly users](#) worldwide — up from 500 million in March. OpenAI launched its updated image generator feature for ChatGPT in March, [and since then, it has seen an uptick in usage in India](#). OpenAI CEO Sam Altman said in a recent podcast that India is [the company's second biggest market](#). With the Go plan, it wants to cash in on that.

According to app analytics firm AppFigures, India has been the leading country in terms of ChatGPT app downloads across platforms, with over 29 million downloads coming from the country in the last 90 days. However, the app only made \$3.6 million in this period from users in the country.

This move will likely nudge more consumers to subscribe to using ChatGPT more, given its pricing. Other AI companies have also made moves to attract users from the country's internet user base of over 850 million. Last month, Perplexity partnered with network provider Airtel to offer [free Perplexity](#).



[Pro subscriptions](#). Google also dished up [a free AI Pro plan for India-based students for one year](#).

While OpenAI's move is not giving out any freebies, local and affordable pricing will likely result in a better subscription conversion rate for ChatGPT in India.

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**Ivan Mehta**

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Ivan covers global consumer tech developments at TechCrunch. He is based out of India and has previously...

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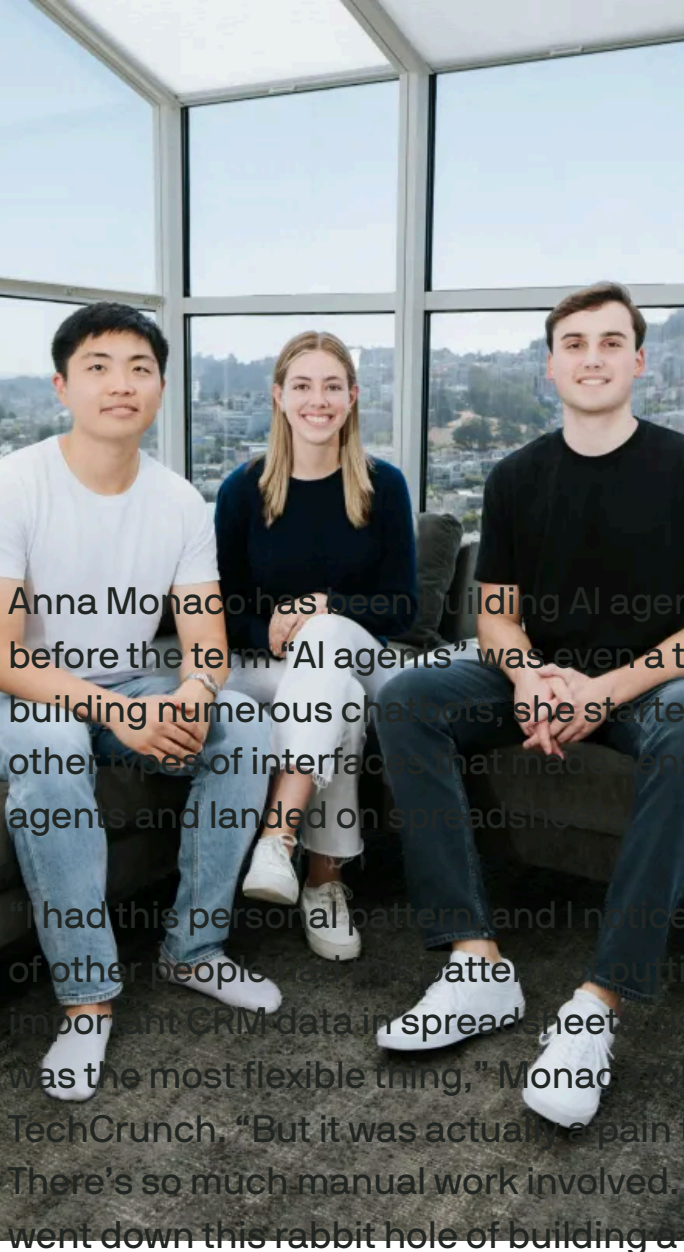


IMAGE CREDITS: PARADIGM

Rebecca Szkutak — 8:00 AM PDT · August 18, 2025

Anna Monaco has been building AI agents since before the term “AI agents” was even a thing. After building numerous chatbots, she started looking for other types of interfaces that made sense for AI agents and landed on spreadsheets.

“I had this personal pattern, and I noticed that a lot of other people had this pattern of putting very important CRM data in spreadsheets. Not because it was the most flexible thing,” Monaco told TechCrunch. “But it was actually a pain to maintain. There’s so much manual work involved. So [I] just went down this rabbit hole of building a product for myself and wanted to reimagine what a spreadsheet could look like with the full power of LLMs.”

The result was [Paradigm](#), an AI-powered spreadsheet equipped with more than 5,000 AI agents. Users can assign different prompts to individual columns and cells, and individual AI agents will crawl the internet to find and fill out the needed information.

Paradigm works with AI models from Anthropic, OpenAI, and Google’s Gemini, Monaco said, and supports model switching.

“We want to support every single model because we want our users to be able to have the highest reasoning outputs when they need it, but also the cheapest outputs,” Monaco said. “It’s just a

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Isabelle Johannessen  
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constant cycle of evaluating different models, working closely with model providers to make sure our limits are high enough, and then giving some of that power to our users.”

The company launched a small closed beta preview in late 2024 and has been iterating on the product using customer feedback. Paradigm attracts users ranging from consultants to sales professionals and finance folks and operates on a subscription model with tiers based on usage. Paradigm counts the consulting firm EY, AI chip startup Etched, and AI coding company Cognition as early customers.

Paradigm is now releasing its product to the public and announcing that it raised a \$5 million seed round led by General Catalyst. The company has raised \$7 million to date. Monaco said the funding will go toward executing on the company’s “extremely aggressive product roadmap.”



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“The interesting thing that happened when we fundraised is some people we pitched just kept on

using and paying for the product,” Monaco said. “I think that was a cool part of it. We found a lot of value from it internally and our investors, not even just our investors — other investors that we talked to — are still using it.”

Paradigm isn’t the only company looking to give spreadsheets an AI upgrade. [Quadratic](#), which has raised more than \$6 million in venture funding, is a 3-year-old startup with a similar goal. Legacy companies like Google and Microsoft are also adding AI tools to their spreadsheet applications.

Monaco said that she doesn’t really consider the competition because Paradigm doesn’t think of itself as an AI-powered spreadsheet. She said she thinks of it as a new AI-powered workflow that happens to be in the familiar form of a spreadsheet but won’t necessarily stay that way forever.

“What I’m seeing in the most popular AI products now is this fine balance between present and future,” Monaco said. “How do you build something that is really powerful and generates a lot of value now but also sets you up really well for the future? That’s the question that I asked myself a year ago when I was starting the company.”

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Becca is a senior writer at TechCrunch that covers venture capital trends and startups. She previously covered the...

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IMAGE CREDITS: FIRECRAWL

STARTUPS

# AI crawler Firecrawl raises \$14.5M, is still looking to hire agents as employees

Julie Bort — 4:00 AM PDT · August 19, 2025



Firecrawl's co-founder and CEO Caleb Pfeffer knew the exact moment he found the investor to lead his Series A.

He was in a coffee meeting with Nexus Venture Partner's Abhishek Sharma at the Blue Bottle in San Francisco's South Park (a favorite VC haunt). While describing the future of the company, he was gesturing so animatedly that his chair tipped over.

"I actually fell out of my chair. And Abhishek, as a great investor does, caught the chair and me as I was falling," Pfeffer described with a laugh. That felt like a symbol for how the founder/investor relationship is supposed to work. "I think that was a clear signal that he was the right partner."

On Tuesday, Firecrawl announced a Series A led by Nexus with participation from Shopify CEO Tobias Lütke and existing investor Y Combinator.

Firecrawl offers a popular open-source web crawler for developers and AI agents, with a commercially supported version available through API. It's used by 350,000 developers, has nearly [50,000 stars](#) on GitHub and its notable customers include Shopify, Replit, and Zapier as well as "some of the largest hedge funds in the world," Pfeffer told TechCrunch. And, he says, the company is already profitable.

The startup also just released an API that supports search and will soon add support for natural language prompts, as co-founder and CTO Nicolas Silberstein Camara noted.

Pfeffer, who co-founded Firecrawl in 2022 with Camara and CMO Eric Ciarla, said gaining Lütke as an investor was "the best kind of validation."

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They landed him through a gutsy email after discovering the Shopify founder had signed up to try their product through their self-service portal.

“We saw his email come in,” Pfeffer said. The Firecrawl crew immediately emailed him to welcome him as a customer, but got no response. Two months later, some Shopify folks contacted Firecrawl for an enterprise contract. So Pfeffer took his shot and emailed Lütke again, mentioning they'd love for him to participate in their upcoming round.

This time, Lütke responded with compliments about their product. He was in.

While AI web crawlers have [a somewhat dubious reputation these days](#), mostly due to bad actors [that ignore robot.txt files](#), they are also a necessary part of the burgeoning AI world. AI trains on the web, [agents need to access web pages to perform their duties](#), and enterprises need personalized crawlers to consume their own websites for training and operations.

The Firecrawl founders also hope to help address the frustrating parts of their industry. They are working on tools to help website owners, publishers, and other content creators “get paid when AI uses their content. We think this is the way it should be,” Peffer said.

While there have been lots of efforts around this idea from big names like [Adobe and Getty](#) as well as startups [like Bria](#), [Calliope Networks](#), and others, Peffer feels that Firecrawl has an edge because it’s already working with those who are scraping data.

“We already have one side of the marketplace,” he said. “What we want to do is just connect that side of the marketplace to the website owners, the publishers.”

Interestingly, Firecrawl also went viral a few months ago for reasons that have little to do with their open source tool. They had posted an [ad to the YC job board looking to hire an AI agent as an employee for a \\$15,000 salary](#) – perhaps the first job ad for an agent employee, ever.

That job search didn’t yield an agent worth hiring, so Firecrawled upped the budget to up [\\$1 million to hire several agents and the developers who built them, and tried again](#). Applicants flooded in, Peffer said, but the company hasn’t yet hired any. The founders realized that evaluating and managing wanna-be agent employees is a job in itself. So now they are looking for an AI chief of staff.

Firecrawl’s Peffer will [be on stage at Disrupt in October](#) to discuss all that he’s learned in a session that covers the pros and cons of hiring AI agents as early employees.

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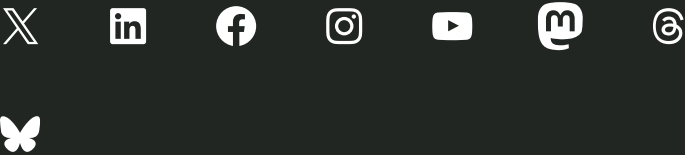
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